

History Primer for Students of the Humanities Lord's University.

**Penned by Dr. Eustace Worthope
In the Imperial Year of 1738.**

Preface

This volume is intended to make the Student of Humanities in the great University of Waldheim prepared for rudimentary discussions of History. The Knowledge contained herein is assumed knowledge for any Student of the Humanities, and will not be further illuminated in any lectures by the Professors at Lord's. This volume is chiefly concerned with the History of the Early Middle Period (c. 1700 BC to 1400 BC) to the present day. There will be some discussion of Early History, which is often referred to as Elder History.

The Knowledge found herein is a compilation from a few significant sources that survived the *Repurgo Imperialis*. Chief amongst these is the *Magnus Corpus Avitus* which was provided by the Seminary of St. Ignatius, most generously and graciously. Other significant primary sources include the *Treatise on the Historical Relevance of the "Tale of the Woodland King"*, the *Chronicle of Vermilund*, and the remnants of the *Corpus Officina Hominum per Gestalt Avarinius*. Numerous other texts and sources are also sited, and are noted appropriately.

On Calendars

For the most part, this volume will reference events using the Imperial Calendar (IC). The 'zero' year of this Calendar is marked by the conquest of the **City of Waldheim** by **Saint Abaddon**. The city was called **Gulfziam** by the Ferals that populated it at that time. It is important to note that the IC was started and restarted many times, and the City changed hands between the Ferals and Men for hundreds of years before Abaddon. The Imperial Calendar year zero also marks the beginning of the period of history known as the **Saeculum Dominae Humanitas a Avilund**, which persists to this day, according to some scholars (some rogues disagree, but that is an issue for modern Civics seminars). Time before year zero is noted as 'Before Conquest', or 'BC', and counts backwards from year zero.

Before the IC, the Men of Avilund marked a new chronicle of years which began with the landing of **Sebald**, **Dunstan** and **Barnabas** in the lands that are now known as the Imperial Ecclesiarchy of Valdenwail. What they called their own calendar is a fact lost to us in the *Repurgo*, but it shall herein, and in most lectures, be referred to as the SHA Calendar, after the period of history known as the **Saeculum Humanitas a Avilund**, which persists to this day, as per discussion above. It is likely that the conquest of Gulfziam by Abaddon was in, or close to, the year 1400 SHA. This puts us very close to the 3150th year of Men in Avilund.

What calendar, if any, was used by the Men that came before Sebald and his crew is a matter for speculation in the post-*Repurgo* world of academics.

The Elder Roll of Years (ERY) will be referenced from time to time. It is not known to modern scholars if the Elders counted years the same way we do, but it is assumed that they called the same revolution of the four seasons one year, as we do. The Seminary of St. Ignatius, after decades of research, insists that the **Collegium Waldheim** were made aware of the ERY in their historic visitation to Waldheim in the year 201 SHA. At this time, they record that the ERY was in its 39,999th year. This puts us at around the 42,900th year of the Elder Roll of Years. This number is, admittedly, overwhelming.

Periods of History

There are several conventions for the naming of periods of History, and there has been very little standardized procedure for this practice, even recently, in post-*Repugo* academics. Different groups with their own interests have identified dozens of different ways to break up our Historical Record. As one can well imagine, canonical texts break most of our History down by the activities of the Saints. Secular organizations choose more far-reaching and important landmarks in History to identify ‘periods’ or ‘eras’. Of course, many different periods overlap as a result of this. It is convention, however, in educated circles, to refer to the following periods of History as being the most definitive;

Early History. This is the period of time before Men came to Avilund. It includes the activities of the Elders in Avilund, and the activities of Men on the Islands, though not much is now known about either of these groups and their doings.

Middle History. This is the period of time in which the lives of the first Saints were lived, including the time of Men coming to Avilund, and up to the conquest of Gulfziam by Abaddon. Some antiquarians draw the curtain on ‘Middle History’ with the final destruction of the Elders, which was around 1199 BC (201 SHA). At Lord’s University, it is understood that an Educated Man is referring to the years circa 1700 BC to 0 IC as ‘Middle History’.

Early Middle History. This is the most nebulous of historical periods, after Elder History. This period is chiefly concerned with the lives of Avitus, Gaul, and the Prime Saints. This period of history is now shrouded in complete obscurity after the *Repurgo*. No actual dates have survived to modern times about the events of this age, and of the events described in the *Tale of the Woodland King*. This age ends in 1400 BC, when Men arrive in Avilund.

Mezzo Middle History. This is the period of time from 1400 BC to 450 BC. This age is sometimes called the **First Age of Imperial Expansion**. It begins with the arrival of Sebald, Dunstan and Barnabas in the legendary vessel known as *Bram’Cairn*. This age, the Saeculum Humanitas a Avilund, marks a tremendous expansion of Men on this continent. In this thousand or so years, Men came to Avilund, and managed to establish the Imperial Ecclesiarchy, and the Imperial boundaries that are, for all intents and purposes, the same as they are today. Some notable dates in this period of history include the following;

1250 BC	Birth of the Primus Deus Fidelis and the laying of the first stones at the Valdenwail.
1199 BC	Founding of the Colleguim Waldheim by Ignatius, Anselm and Gratus .
450 BC	Invasion of Brogard the Cruel. The ancient city of Tiberwail (the location of the modern day city of Lysander) is destroyed, and the Horde marches up to the walls of the Valdenwail. The <i>Epic of Lazarus of Duneedin</i> tells this tale pretty well, and the head of Brogard can still be viewed in the Cathedral of St.Lazarus in Duneedin today.

Although the huge feral Horde lead by Brogard was defeated, the Empire had been crippled and nearly destroyed. The unchecked advance of Men in Avilund had come to a halt, and a period of slow rebuilding followed.

Late Middle History. 450 BC to 0. This short bit of history is characterized by the worse times that Men in Avilund ever had to endure. The slow reclaiming of Imperial territories was difficult. Not only had the Ferals taken root in many lands, but the new inhabitants of the Eastern shores of Avilund, the **Kells**,

had arrived. These warlike, robust and violent men of the Eastern Archipelago were very cunning and determined foes, and remain on this continent today, though in the far North. This is a brief period of history, but one which produced many heroes and saints. Chief among the heroes and saints of this time is Abaddon, the Liberator of Waldheim. Though he invaded the Feral-held City no less than 13 times, in the year 0, he took it, and it has not left the control of Men since.

Late History. This is the period of time from year 0 IC to the present day. It is a tumultuous time for Men and for Empire, and it can be divided into dozens, even hundreds of significant periods of time. However, there are, like Middle History, three commonly acknowledged subdivisions of this period.

Early Late History. 0 to 750. This age is also known as the **Second Age of Imperial Expansion.** This age is typified by very strong Scions and Prelates with warlike personalities and the wills to match. Great Pilgrimages and Crusades happen during this time. Previous to the *Repurgo*, this was the most widely studied period of History. It is during this time that Men begin to unearth the libraries and relics of the Elders in Waldheim and other Elder Cities. **New Magic** was studied and employed by Men, and it is from this time that most Artifacts originate. This was a violent time, but a time of great advances for the culture of Men and acts of great heroism. Colonies were established in the Eastern Archipelago and in the lands beyond the Barrier Wood and the Sea of Sorrow.

This golden age of Men ended in 750 when the **Black Faith** first reared its hideous face. We know that the Scion **Nicetus Avitus Vanderwail** (700-804) revealed the **Prospectus Imperialis ex Daemonica** in November of 750. This document was a heavy handed policy that gave birth to the **First Inquisition.**

Middle Late History. 750-1348. With the birth of the Inquisition, the Empire of Men ceased its expansion immediately, and quickly lost ground to the Ferals, Kells, and other inhabitants of the lands in the new colonies. This age is typified by the tyranny of the Scions (with some exceptions), and the crumbling of the Society and Culture of Men. The hallmarks of this terrible time are illuminated most clearly during the **Repurgo Imperialis.** This 138-year tragedy begins in 1210 in the little-known hamlet of Sandalstone, where the Casparian Monk, David, emerged with his torch and hatred for all things academic. Though the *Repurgo* was started by a crazed vigilante, it soon had a powerful ally in the **Second Inquisition**, which was called for in 1295 by **Baudri the Bloody, Baudri Avitus Vanderwail** (1210-1350). This time is characterized by the horrible misdeeds of Men against Men, and though it was a time of conflagration for records, books, documents and all other forms of history, enough documents and tales about this time survived its own fires.

Middle Late History ends in 1348 with the **Novae res Sanquinius.** There is an entire sub-specialty of History that deals with the Revolution, from its causes to its effects upon the modern world, and this volume will not go into much of that detail. The Student of the Humanities is encouraged to read Dr. Carrington's *Cruentus Novae res Sanquinius Satus Compleo* for a greater understanding of this monumental turning point in history. It must be understood at this point, though, that the Empire as it was came to an end during this Revolution, and the power of the Saintly Faith dwindled dramatically in many parts of what was the Empire. The Empire, as it had been, was changed for ever, and some rogues actually insist that it came to an end outside the Hedge of the Valdenwail, when Baudri signed the *Placitum a Terminus Potentia*, on October 30, 1348. This document relinquished the control of the City of Avitus (modern day Waldheim) from the hands of the Vanderwails, and brought an end to the rule of the Saintly Faith in all but a few territories. If it had not been for the bloody policies of Baudri's Inquisition, this might never have happened.

Modern History. 1348-present. After the *Placitum* was signed, the Empire changed dramatically, and the whole face of Avilund was re-sculpted. This era is marked at its beginning by the end of the Revolution in 1348, but just as characteristic of this age is the renewed interest in the Holy Archipelago (the Eastern Archipelago) and the lost colonies in the West. The 3rd Crusade was launched in 1350 by Baudri, and in 1488, the Fourth Crusade was launched by **Eustace Avitus Vanderwail**, who is known as the **Crusading Scion.** Many old laws were repealed in many parts of Avilund (at this point, most scholars except the most proud use the term 'Avilund' rather than 'Empire' to refer to the lands of Men on the continent), and a new age of invention and discovery soon took hold, and was promptly labeled

the **Saeculum Ingenium Aurum** by scholars here at Lord's. In many places, the City of Waldheim especially, Institutions of Learning again sprung up, though this was a slow process; the long years of the *Repurgo* and it's infection in the psyche of Avilund had made a lasting and durable obstacle to progress. This age is typified by such things as the great inventions of Gun Powder and the Printing Press, the Bank and the Corporation. Peace and prosperity had come, at long last, to most parts of Avilund, except some border nations, and, of course, the Crusading Theatres.

It is important to note that despite the modernization of Avilund, contact with the colonies in the Crusading Theatres was not fully established, and in 1510, with the death of Eustace in the Western Theatre, the last contact with the ancient colonies of the Empire was lost permanently. At the time of publication of this volume, it has been 228 years since Men entered either Theatre and returned.

Early History

There are two important regions to consider, when discussing Early History, and this section shall be divided between them; the Eastern Archipelago, and Avilund.

Early History, for Men, occurs exclusively in the Eastern Archipelago, where it is surmised that Men originate from. The only record of any kind about this area is the *Tale of the Woodland King*, which gives us a look at the Archipelago in transition. This tale comes at the end of a presumably long age of strife and turmoil in the Archipelago, though we know little of the source of this trouble. The characters in the *Tale* are the only names we know of this entire region, though before the *Repurgo*, there were many works which gave further light to this region. The First and Second Crusades came back with an abundance of artifacts, documents, history and tales about this region, but none are now to be found anywhere. There is much speculative fiction about this region in this time, but the only hard facts come from the *Tale*, which is just that; a tale.

It is important to note that during this time, the Elders had already prospered and were in their Autumnal Years as a society in Avilund. We know a little of what they had been up to during the time before Men came to Avilund, through the records of the Collegium Waldheim, many of which are preserved by the vigilant keepers of the Seminary of St. Ignatius. It is certain that they were engaged in a war of millennia with the Ferals, and that they had some sort of great inner struggle as well, which was instrumental in their decline and final ruination. Before Men came to Avilund the Elders had colonized the entire continent, though by the time Men came, many places had been uninhabited for thousands of years, and many were overrun with the Ferals.

Some scholars argue that Early history ends in 201 SHA, when Ignatius, Anselm and Gratus visited Waldheim, and escaped just before its fall to the Ferals, and the destruction of Last Elders of Waldheim. This is an Elderocentric view, which is a valid academic argument, but most credible professors and students of history will acknowledge that Early History ends in 1400 BC, 0 SHA, with the arrival of men in the Elder Dénouement.

Early Middle History

In 1400 BC, the legendary vessel *Bram'Cairn* arrived in Avilund. It departed from an island which was once well known to Men, but today, we do not even know the name of it, or its exact whereabouts. In fact, since the *Repurgo*, there isn't even a useable map of the Archipelago to examine or guess at. However, we do know that Men came from the Eastern Archipelago, and we do know some of the names and deeds of that time. Today, the only document that survives time is the *Tale of the Woodland King*, which is the account of Ignatius, written upon his journey across the sea, about the events of the Prime Saints. This is not a historical document, however. It is just as it advertises; a 'Tale'. However, for over 3000 years it has been commonly accepted as being full of more truths than exaggerations, and numerous other documents about the time before the SHA referenced it with reverence. And so it is today that we accept that the *Tale* is indeed a valuable historical document. Most literate people in Avilund have read this account, and many of those have numerous passages memorized. The clergy of St. Ignatius have, long ago, divided the *Tale* into many numbered passages like some sort of alchemy text, and it is known that they study the

Numerology of the *Tale* as its own matter. Much of this cabalistic practice is obscure to even the most enlightened and Saintly of scholars here at Lord's, this author included.

The constituent elements of the *Tale* must herein be discussed briefly, in case the new Student of Humanities has not had the benefit of reading this most ubiquitous of manuscripts. The *Tale* begins, like all Early Literature, with a cosmic display of portent. And in this display, one can see why the faithful of St. Ignatius' began their cabalistic endeavours of numerology. A great meteor shower begins, and it lasts for 11 nights. It pauses for 3 nights, and then goes on for another 11 nights. It is not within the scope of this text to discuss the impact that these opening stanzas of the *Tale* might have had on our Society, but it should be obvious to even the slowest of thinkers that the description of this protracted bout of falling comets is the very root of Cabalistic Numerology, the study of which still causes panic even in this Age of Enlightenment. At the end of the meteor shower, **Avitus** himself is born to a nameless mother. Three years later, his brother **Gaul** is born. The *Tale* describes in some brief but poetic detail the early years of the Prime Saint, Avitus.

Then, the first of the Lessons begins, with the tale of the struggle of Avitus against his brother, Gaul. Gaul, who covets his brother's wife, **Ruth**, plots to take her away. He kills their four children, or at least he thinks he does; **Mairin**, the nursemaid of the children, steals away with the youngest child, **Severinius**, exchanging her own infant son in order to fool Gaul. When the village elders learn that Mairin has fled, and the children of Ruth and Avitus are found dead, it is she that is blamed for the misdeed. This enrages Gaul, who was hoping to frame his brother for the act.

Gaul decides to do something else to ruin his brother's marriage, and next rapes and kills their sister, **Muriel**. This time, he is able to frame his brother for the act, and Avitus is subsequently made a criminal, and forced to flee for his life. Avitus manages to convince his father that he did not do this terrible thing, and goes into hiding while his father travels to the village to clear his name. However, Gaul intercepts his father, and learns of his intent to clear his son's name, and kills the man. Avitus is thus condemned, and he spends the next 33 years wandering in the wilderness. Some theological scholars believe that it is this year that Gaul made his legendary pact with a trio of devils, and that the 3333rd anniversary of this pact will be in 1783 IC.

The *Tale* spends a troubling amount of verse describing the happy relationship that Gaul and Ruth enjoy after the departure of Avitus. Ruth is clearly not the same woman after the tragedies that Gaul inflicted upon her, but Gaul manages to deceive her fully, and she does indeed grow to love him, though she has no children by him (though some theological scholars disagree; this is not within the scope of this volume). Eventually Avitus returns with his son, Severinius and Muriel, who he has found in the wilderness, and made amends with. The three of them confront Ruth, and tell her the truth. Gaul learns that he has been revealed as an evil, plotting murderer, and he flees. Ruth and Avitus are rejoined as husband and wife, and they again conceive. By this time, Severinius has taken over the role of leader on the Island, as Avitus has sworn to hunt to the ends of the earth to find and destroy Gaul.

After some time, Avitus returns home to find that Gaul has returned in his absence and captured Ruth. Gaul is able to take the form of his nephew, Severinius, and manages to capture Avitus thusly. Avitus is bound and forced to watch Gaul rape and murder Ruth, who is quite pregnant at the time. This is too much for Avitus to bear; he breaks his bonds, and the two brothers fight for a period of time (this time is argued by some to be 3 days, by others 33, and 333 by others yet; again, this theological dispute is not suitable for the limited scope of this volume). At any rate, the end result was that Gaul and Avitus destroyed each other and transcended this world; a theological first. These are the first 2 souls to have supposedly entered the Valley of Death, and embarked upon the Journey Beyond Death.

It should be noted here that Ruth has never been Sainted in the PDF. She is assumed to have died too soon for her soul to embark on the Journey. However, though her name has been kept out of the Prime Pantheon, it has not faded into obscurity, though some Prime Saints have. Worship of Ruth is interdicto fides according to the PDF, but despite the best efforts of two inquisitions and other great measures, she continues to issue forth as whispers on the lips of many women.

The bulk of the *Tale* is actually about Severinius. It is Saint Sever that is the *Woodland King* that the title speaks of, and it is his actions and the actions of his contemporaries that are described in the bulk of the *Tale*. Shortly after the transcendence of his father and uncle, Sever brings unification to the warring tribes of the Eastern Archipelago, and is the first Man to be called a King. The *Tale* describes in some length a few important figures; **Ida**, the Angel Messenger that took on a mortal form to wed Sever, and their children **Dunstan**, and **Sebald**. The pantheon of the 11 Prime Saints is further fleshed out in the later parts of the *Tale*, as it illustrates the lives of some contemporaries of the descendants of Avitus discussed above; **Ulric**, the rival and companion of Dunstan, **Caspar** and **Caanan**, the disciples of Severinius, and **Judith**, the wife of Sebald. These names should be familiar to even the least Saintly, save the name of Caanan, who, even to this author, is an enigma. It is not within the scope of this volume to discuss the stories of these individuals, remarkable though they may be. It is just important to know that, in the Modern Age, much of what we know about these Saints can be verified only through examination of this document.

Of course, the *Tale* is the work of **Ignatius**. The life of Ignatius is probably the most sanguineously disputed topic in theology and theological politics today. Through some documents that have survived the *Repurgo*, we know that the origins of Ignatius have been debated ever since the *Contentio Investatus* of 1350 (some scholars are now calling this the *Prima Contentio Investatus*, in light of modern politics which are, again, outside the scope of this volume). The Canon of St. Ignatius has long held that Ignatius was aboard *Bram'Cairn* when it crossed the Eastern Ocean and arrived on these shores, and that Ignatius interviewed the likes of Dunstan and Sebald during the crossing. This position makes Ignatius long lived indeed, as he is known to have visited Waldheim and met with the Last Elders over 200 years later. There are records of many men living into their hundreds, but few over 200, and those are all descendants of Ida and Sever (Angelspawn). It is a more popular position amongst the *Primus Deus Fidelis* that Ignatius came to Avilund in a later journey of *Bram'Cairn*, and that he was not in fact a contemporary of Sebald, Dunstan and Barnabas. Others yet argue that Ignatius must have been born and raised in Avilund, and that his clear and haunting depictions of the lands of the Eastern Archipelago are but the product of the mind of a prodigy of literature.

At any rate, a discussion of the life of Ignatius leads us to

Mezzo Middle History

There has been little to no debate over the fact that in 1400 BC, the vessel *Bram'Cairn* arrived in Avilund. The location of its landing is somewhat disputed, though the answer to that question is undeniably hidden in the Valdenwail. To be sure, the ship landed close to the present day location of the Valdenwail, and most certainly within the confines of the Imperial Ecclesiarchy of Valdenwail (IEV). This land was then described as fertile and verdant beyond imagining for the Men of the Islands, though this description does not hold today. By all accounts, the IEV is one of the bleakest places in the quondam Empire today. In those days it was ideally suited for colonization, and it is **Judith**, the wife of Sebald, who is credited with the agricultural taming of those lands. But let us line up some facts as we know them, in order.

1400 BC *Bram'Cairn* arrives in Avilund, with Dunstan, Sebald and Barnabas aboard. Dunstan and Sebald stay in Avilund, and Barnabas returns home as Captain of the ship. This marks the beginning of the *Saeculum Humanitas a Avilund*. It is important to note that Barnabas holds the unique theological position of being a native of the Archipelago, but not a member of the Prime Pantheon. This may well be because of an obstinate tendency towards numerology and the number 11, and therefore a lack of space for him (and Ruth) in the Prime Pantheon. However, some have argued that the origins of Barnabas are uncertain, as they are not detailed in the *Tale*; he is given but a passing reference as the captain of the ship, and nothing more.

1398 BC There was ample documentation before the *Repurgo* that Ulric and a large host of Men from the Islands came and settled Avilund, and from this time forth, migration by ship from the Islands to Avilund persists, for perhaps 100 years or so. This marks the beginning of the *Saeculum Maximus Congrecius*. Sometime after this, Judith, an immigrant from the Islands arrives and marries Sebald. Theirs

is the first recorded marriage in Avilund, and their ceremony is very closely followed by the Saintly of both of those Canons today.

1250 BC The first stones of the Valdenwail are laid this year, in order to contain the **Rule of St. Avitus**, which was penned by Sebald. This is the year that is commonly accepted as the formal birth of the Primus Deus Fidelis, as the first PDF document is revealed. Though Sebald is known to have died shortly after this document is revealed, Men experience an unchecked expansion on the continent at this point, for hundreds of years. Agricultural Historians and Natural Scientists suggest that this is largely due to the mastery of farming techniques that Judith had begun, and successful animal husbandry techniques. Certainly, dozens of towns and some small cities spring up from this date forward, and this expansion does not stop for 800 years.

It is important to note that the *Tale* makes no mention of either the Valdenwail, or the Rule of St. Avitus, though it does mark the arrival of Ulric, nearly towards its end. Thus, we can narrow the date of publication of the *Tale* between 1398 BC – 1250 BC. There are scholars who have devoted their entire careers and lives to narrowing this large margin, somewhat, but all in vain. Too little evidence survived the *Repurgo*, and mores the pity.

1206 BC Death of Ulric in the maw of **Razzlethorn**. This beast is described in many tales that have survived the centuries. However, it has been described as everything from a great Dragon, to a huge Spider, and many other things besides. The death of Ulric is significant; he is the last of the Prime Pantheon, and probably the last Archipelago native to draw breath in Avilund. His death is also a sign to the heathen Ferels, who have been held at bay by Ulric and his Knights for decades. With his death, **Vestus the Pestilent** raises a great hoard which marches through the last Elder State, and right up to the walls of Waldheim, beginning a 7 year siege.

1199 BC This is one of the most studied years in Middle History. In this year, the Elder Society is drawing its final breath; the Siege of Vestus seems imminently complete, as the Elder resistance is all but worn down. Ignatius, Anselm and Gratus manage to sneak into the City, and they meet with the Elders for the last time. It is known that Sebald had met the Elders, and that he respected them, and especially, their architecture, which he tried to emulate. However, there are no surviving records detailing any meeting between Sebald or any other Men, and the Elders, and thus the visitation of 1199 BC is significant. These three men, who form an organization known as the **Collegium Waldheim**, spend several weeks with the last Elders, learning all they can from them. There are entire books and courses of study devoted to this historic last meeting of the Young Race and the Elder, and again, it is not within the scope of this volume to explore this encounter. At the end of the visit, Vestus breaks through the gates, and the time of the Elders is concluded. The Collegium Waldheim manages to escape, fortunately.

It is vital to the understanding of our Culture, that the student of Humanities understands that a seed was planted in the hearts and minds of Men in 1199 BC. The Collegium extolled the virtues and achievements of the Elders, and to this day, Men still perceive themselves as a race that is not only younger than the Elders, but markedly inferior. Much of this complex comes from the deification (later outlawed) of the Elders by Ignatius, Anselm and Gratus, and though it may have left the Men of Avilund feeling somewhat second grade, it compelled an even greater effort of expansion and colonization, and the discovery of all things Elder.

The Collegium is also significant, because it is the first Institute of Learning for Men. Before this time, we had but a crude alphabet and nearly complete illiteracy. After 1199, however, there was a new focus on education and research. Of course, Ignatius, the Saint of Knowledge, Academia and Cartographers, was the father of a variety of disciplines. Gratus, the Saint of Medecine, learned his first Humours from the Elders, and of course, went on to develop medicine in relative leaps and bounds. Anselm is the Saint and Father of New Magic for Men in Avilund, and it was with the Elders in his short visitation that he learned his first cantrip. These men began to study and teach these things to others, though not in the classroom setting that one would imagine today. The study of their academic lives will bring the student of Humanities to appreciate the Modern Age and all of its amenities and comforts in Academia.

Finally, with regards to the Collegium Waldheim, it should be noted that they did indeed have a building, the first school of Men, in fact, in the Valdenwail. We call it the College today, for lack of knowing its true name, if one does indeed exist. For over 2 millennia, this building (of which no description survived the *Repurgo*) was the destination of pilgrimage for the saintly of the three founding Saints and a host of others besides. However, no visitor from outside the superannuated and hermetic walls of the Valdenwail has set foot in the College since 1210.

1099 BC In the hundred years since the fall of Waldheim to the Ferals, Men had made tremendous progress on the continent. There are several large towns and two cities (Tiberwail and Duneedin). Men have pushed back their boundaries significantly, perhaps as far as 200 miles from their stronghold in the Valdenwail. In this year, **Clavo Avitus Vanderwail** (1184-1033 BC), though already known by the title of Scion, declares himself the Emperor of Avilund, and the unification of State and Faith is made fast. Until this time, the leadership of Men had alternated between the two estates, and the towns and villages had their own autonomy and chose governments of their own styling. Indeed, some villages were ruled by heathen councils, still hanging on to the Old Faith of the Archipelago (that which predates the Saintly Faith).

Things were ripe on the continent for this political change. For starters, the ships from the Archipelago had stopped coming to these shores. It is suspected that great wars were ravaging the Archipelago, likely with the Kells deeply involved, or perhaps organized Island Ferals. This is all speculation. What isn't speculation is that the last ship to arrive in the Grey Harbour was the *Cariegh Raeigh*. This ship crashed into the port by either tremendous chance, or Saintly Guidance, for not a living soul walked aboard that vessel, which has become the topic of many an Epic, Romance, and lesser works of fiction since her portentous arrival on these shores. The continental ferals were also in a stage of organization which threatened many of the towns and villages. Many requests for help from the Valdenwail were answered, but only after fealty had been sworn to the Scion.

Though the Scion chose the title of Emperor, he was actually a hereditary king, and his 'Empire' a kingdom, with all the complexities of fealty and vassalage that one can find in the Kingdoms on the continent today. However, by whatever name, the Empire was born, and the Men of Avilund had forged something new and unique to themselves, apart from their island ancestry. And though political semantics can cause interminable debate about the qualities of the 'Empire', doubtless the system worked. By the time Clavo died in 1033, there were settlements in the northern regions today known as Wellenlund and Isenwald, which are hundreds of miles from the Valdenwail. Siege had been laid to Gulfziam (the Feral name for Waldheim) a number of times, but it was never taken in this time.

450 BC After 650 years of Imperial expansion, the borders of the Empire reached boundaries which they have not crossed even today. Dozens of cities and large towns could be found all over Avilund, and many Elder settlements had been discovered, explored, and resettled. The system of Canon Law had been well established by this time, and the rule of the Vanderwails was absolute, and mostly benign. However, a great threat came in the form of a new hoard of ferals, under the intelligent leadership of **Brogard the Cruel**. Brogard razed dozens of towns and entire provinces of the Empire, including the great city of Tiberwail, which was rebuilt centuries later as Lysander.

By October, Brogard had marched upon the Valdenwail, and indeed laid siege to those inviolable walls. Brogard's was the only army to ever sight the walls of the Imperial City itself. **Lazarus of Duneedin**, then a General of the Imperial Host, put an end to Brogard's rampage. *The Epic of Lazarus of Duneedin*, of which many copies still exist today, tells this tale best. In short, Lazarus first met Brogard in the streets of his native city as it was razed to the ground, and was terribly wounded in the exchange. Though Duneedin was destroyed, Lazarus managed to escape with a couple thousand soldiers and refugees, and retreated to the Valdenwail. There, he rallied his forces and the garrison left at the castle, and managed to hold off the siege of Brogard from October until December. That winter was brutally cold, and Lazarus is credited with the foresight to hold off his counter attack until weeks of bitter cold had taken the edge of his opponents. Outnumbered by over 10:1, Lazarus and his men marched out in the middle of a terrible storm to attack their foes, and Lazarus himself took the head from Brogard, which was the mortal wound of

not only Brogard, but of his hoard and rampage. The hoard broke and consumed itself soon afterwards, but in its fragmenting, it continued to cause harm to the every corner of the empire. Indeed, in 435 BC, a group of Ferals who had been raiding a road in the IEV were killed by a group of knights, and they were found to be wearing threadbare tabards from Brogard's personal guard.

Though Brogard's rampage was ended, the Empire, as it had been for over 600 years, had been crippled. The unchecked expansion of Men in Avilund came to an end, and for hundreds of years, there was little communication between the various states of the Empire. Indeed, small feudal kingdoms sprung up again in places that had previously accepted the Imperial Rule. This step backward was born of necessity, as there were no Imperial troops to protect many of these places. The separation of many of these states from not only the Imperial Rule, but of the Canonical Rule was bitter and lasting; in Mantlethorn and Hiergallad never fully recovered from the hardships of the years to follow, and during the Second Age of Imperial Expansion, these two regions never fully accepted the Primogeniture of the Scion, and during the *Repurgo*, these Kingdoms were instrumental in bringing about the end of the Rule of the Scion.

Late Middle History

This is one of the most commonly accepted periods of history; it is sharply defined by the year 450 BC, with the destruction of Brogard's hoard at the outset, and the conquest of Gulfziam by Abaddon at its termination. This age goes by many names; Twilight Ages, Age of Rebuilding, Age of Sorrow, Age of Fragmentation, and many others besides.

During this period of History, Men in Avilund struggled to reclaim the territories lost to the invasion of Brogard. While things in the south of the Empire progressed smoothly, in the middle-continent and the north, it was more difficult. These states were farther from Imperial support, and Feral populations had been historically larger and more troublesome in those territories as well. In the north, reclaiming the Imperial territories was further hindered by the arrival, in 244 BC of the Kells.

The arrival of the Kells in 244 BC is well documented. They arrived in a great fleet of hundreds of oar- and sail-drawn rakers from the Eastern waters, with a host of perhaps some tens of thousands. They landed north of Hiergallad, and have troubled that kingdom ever since. The Kells were met immediately with force by the Knights of Hiergallad, who, despite having great numbers and the advantage of a defensive position, were not prepared for the ferocity of the Kells, who fought in an unordered and completely different manner than the Knights were prepared for. Their savagery in battle made even the Continental Ferals look civilized by comparison. It is difficult to say how things might have been different, if the King of Heirgallad had extended the olive branch rather than the sword, but perhaps the Empire might have found a new ally. The Kells never seemed more than mildly interested in the lands south of Hiergallad, and have only ever attacked peripheral towns and villages of that Kingdom since their arrival 2000 years ago. Indeed, the Kells seemed more interested in the coastal areas north of the Imperial borders, and likely fought countless more battles with the Ferals than with Men.

Though the Kells were (and are) terribly vicious opponents when provoked, they actually preferred (and still do) to settle land and property disputes with one-on-one combat with champions. Once the King of Heirgallad learned of this tradition in the Kells, he quickly embraced the custom, which was not too far removed from the Right of Challenge which the knights and other nobility of Heirgallad and other kingdoms already practiced. Unfortunately, it took until the year 105 BC before King Garamond of Heirgallad figured this out, and the countryside of the Kingdom was a place of constant war for those intervening years. However, in 105 BC, King Garamond held council with the Kellish Warlord Raigth, over a land dispute on the edge of the kingdom. They decided to settle it themselves, by having their champions fight to the death to determine the outcome. Fighting for Garamond was Edgar Steadholme, a knight of great renown. For Raigth, a barbarian named Klunaigh took the field. Songs of this battle are still sung on both sides of the Kell/Heirgallad border to this day. It was an epic affair of some hours, in which the two killed a great many spectators with their dervish-like melee. Indeed, King Garamond was struck on the hand and lost 3 fingers by the blade of his own Champion, and Raigth's son was slain by the thrown axe of his. Despite the collateral injuries, the terms of the dispute were held, and it did not escalate

into a free-for-all, though the songs do intone that any lesser Men would have let it devolve. In the end, both Champions killed each other, and the province was declared a neutral ground, on which a great lodge has stood ever since. This battle brought relative peace to the region, and an understanding between those two peoples. Even today, it is not unheard of for challenges to be issued from either side of the border for a duel of champions. Peace there was not absolute though; small scale raiding and skirmishing lasted there for centuries to come.

The story of the battle of Klunaigh and Steadholme is typical of the age. This was an age of fighting and war, and most stories that have survived this time are those of heroic deeds of battle. Many Saints emerged in this heroic time, but one must not get the impression that life was all fighting and glory. In fact, life for almost all people of Avilund was typified by hunger, fear and doubt. That a few brave souls could rise above the pervading squalor and famine of this age to fight the heroic battles for which the age is mostly associated with is worth mentioning, but it should not be confused for the standard of life then.

Towards the edge of this age, Abaddon of Ezlonia was born to a relatively wealthy noble family in Mantlethorn. He became a Knight in the Order of Ulric by the time he was 18, and was an accomplished hero of many battles by the age of 20. He earned his laurels fighting the Kells in the north, but it wasn't long before he was called to a higher duty; in the service of his order (and, no doubt, pursuing his own family interest) in the north. A group of Collegium scholars and a priest of St. Ignatius put the idea in Abaddon's head that it would be the noblest of ventures to take the city of Gulfziam (Waldheim) from the Ferals, and he began his own personal campaign to liberate the City. Abaddon laid siege to the City no less than 13 times in as many years, and actually set foot on its hallowed streets a number of times before his final liberation of the City. The life of Abaddon and his conquest of Waldheim is the focus of study for many scholars and historians, and shall not be expanded further within these pages. The author refers the reader to the Holy Repository of the Canon of St. Abaddon in Waldheim, where the deeds of this Saint have been more than adequately recorded and preserved. The conquest of Waldheim begins the two commonly-discussed historical periods; the **Saeculum Dominae Humanitas a Avilund**, which persists to this day, and the **Saeculum Imperiosus Luxamentum Secundus**, or the Second Age of Imperial Expansion.

Late History

With the conquest of Walheim by Abaddon, historians mark the beginning of the Late Period. Late History is a time that is most associated with the slow expansions and contractions of the Empire, as it tries to expand into the Holy Theatres, and struggles with a new-found enemy. It is in Late History that the scholar will first read of the 'Black Faith', and witness the erosion of the Society of Man from the inside, which made his expansion and dominion difficult. Late History is divided into 3 commonly accepted periods; Early Late History (0 to 750), Middle Late History (750 to 1348), and Modern History (1348 to present).

Early Late History

Before the *Repurgo*, this was the most widely studied period of History. This period is marked by the great migration of Men of the Empire into the Holy Theatres, known as the Crusades, and the unearthing, study, and development of the Magic of the Elders (called "New Magic" by Scholars of the Arcane; this age is sometimes called the Age of New Magic by practitioners of the Art). During this period, the Scion sits as Emperor in the City of Abaddon (the name given to Gulfziam after Abaddon's conquest, by the not-so-humble conqueror himself), and has dominion over all the lands from Lyasander and the Valdenwail, to Heirgallad in the far North. With the excavations of the Elder Cities, Men learn road and bridge improvements that allow for a vast infrastructure for the Empire which makes the transporting of troops, supplies, goods and information quicker, safer and more efficient than had previously been imagined by the fearful Men of the Dark Ages. This is a tumultuous time, but also a time of great expansions of the Empire, and the furtherance of the Society of Men in Avilund. Some of the important dates of this age are listed, below;

244-248 The Armed Pilgrimage (First Crusade) to the Eastern Theatre
 334-518 Pilgrimage of the Pilgrims of Vander (Second Crusade) to the Eastern Theatre
 548-594 Pilgrimage of the Ordo Croceus Cervus (Third Crusade) to the Western Theatre
 528 Massacre at St. Irenaeus
 639 Massacre at Tarmin
 750 Massacre at the Cathedral of St. Avitus, Waldheim, Black Faith unmasked.

One of the greatest archaeological finds of all time is the Valde Aula Waldheim; the Great Hall of the Elders. The hall was unearthed by the Scholars and Priests of St. Ignatius that had motivated and followed around Abaddon for twenty years. The Hall would have been a find of the first order if nothing but the floor was found; for upon the floor was a map of the Elder Civilization on the Continent. This map was used to locate dozens of other ruins. The Hall was also full of a great deal of Elder History in the form of carved friezes and statuary. This find was instrumental in the development of New Magic, as one of the ruins later uncovered provided most of the materials Men needed to further their study of the Magic of the Elders, and lead to a proliferation of practitioners of magic and artifacts. This find also secured the fiscal and political strength of the Canon of St. Ignatius, which it still enjoys to this day.

As the roads of the Empire became safer, and her borders more secure, it wasn't long in this age before Men started to look beyond their borders. By 244, **Scion Innocentus** (198-281) inspired a great movement known as the Armed Pilgrimage, after his Oratory of Faith, on July 1, 244, in the Blue Square of Abaddon. Emissaries of the Scion traveled throughout the Empire inciting the Clergy and Nobility to arms, and by September of 245, a host of men and ships which had not been seen since the *Saeculum Maximus Congrecius* was assembled in the Bay of St. Barnabas, and they departed before the winter storms that year for the Eastern Archipelago, to locate, pacify and colonize the Holy Birthplace of St. Avitus. By all surviving accounts, they did indeed locate the archipelago, and established the first colonies there, but contact with those colonies (and Scion Innocentus, who had traveled to the home of his ancestors) was lost in 281, and would not be reestablished for decades.

In 333, an auspicious year for the superstitious people of this age, a timely meteor shower in November persisted for 11 days and threw the Empire into chaos. Many feared that the time of Men was about to end. However, a clever Scion, **Lothar the Unifier** (301-389) claimed to have been visited in his sleep by St. Avitus. His ancestor, he claims, explained off the meteor shower as a great host of Angels that had flown from Heaven into Hell to wage war, and that the time had come to emulate the deeds of Angels here on Earth. He promptly changed the name of the city of Abaddon to St. Avitus (a name which is still used by many of the staunch canons of the PDF), and many other places besides, in order to inflate the currency and façade of power of the Empire and the Canon of St. Avitus.

For all the transparencies in his strategy to unify the panicked and fragmenting Empire, it worked. On December 7, 333, **Luke of Abaddon**, the patriarch of the **Ulmar Family**, mobilized the entire resources of his Family, and much of the military strength of the Canon of St. Ulric, of which he was a senior clergyman, pledging to serve the Scion in whatever capacity the Scion might choose. Luke had been to the Eastern Archipelago in his youth, and had fought many battles against the ferals on land, and against the Kells at sea. By the spring of 334, there were again hundreds of nobles and clergymen from a number of families and many of the militant canons assembled in the Bay of St. Barnabas. They had all been inculcated into a new Order; the **Pilgrims of Vander**, which still exists in some small capacity in Lysander today. Then, as now, The Pilgrims of Vander were answerable ultimately to the Scion, with a High Marshal (Luke was the first) leading them. They were given a charter by the Scion, and granted lands in many parts of the Continental Empire, as well as promises of lands in the Holy Archipelago. Instrumental to the success of this second 'Crusade' was the shortage of land in the Empire worth fighting for. It is speculated that the number of nobles in the Empire was at its historical zenith in that very year of 334, and second-sons and lesser nobles were likely enticed by the promise of lands of their own in the Theatre, if only they fought.

The fleet took the entire Summer and Autumn to finally assemble, but by late October of 334, 50,000 men pledged to serve the Scion and follow the High Marshall into the Theatre. Before the *Repurgo*, this Crusade was studied in-depth as its own matter by scores of Historians. While some few literary works

detailing this Crusade have survived, there were thousands of books and maps detailing every aspect of this Crusade before the fires of David of Sandalstone sought them out. The criminals of the *Repurgo* seemed to seek out works about this Crusade in particular, and took every measure and risk to destroy the hundreds of maps that had recorded the details of this crusade.

Fortunately, in recent years a few texts have been uncovered, though no maps, regarding this Crusade. The numbers of men partaking in this event is well documented in more than one source, but references to 'The Great Album', suggest that a complete roster was made of every man and horse that set foot on one of the boats of the fleet. It is well documented that King Gamaliel of Heirgallad, and King Tomas of Mantlethorn boarded the boats themselves with over 1000 men each. There were many Prelates and Arch Bishops amongst the men, with Golgatha, Prelate of the Canon of St. Ulric acting as the spiritual head of the expedition, and second-in-command.

On October 19, 334 the fleet departed. In late Spring of the following year, news of it's great success started to sail back to the Empire, and further fueled the Crusade. A second wave of ships and men departed in 335 for the Archipelago. Today, it is uncertain how many colonies were reestablished, and how many new ones were founded, but it is certain there were many. For nearly 200 years, men choked the docks of St. Barnabas to get on board any ship heading to the East, for a chance at prospering from the adventurous activities of this Crusade. Indeed, many ships returned laden with great wealth, and tales about the Pilgrims of Vander and their vast success abounded. However, something else came back with the ships along with wealth; tales of a strange religion practiced by the inhabitants of the old colonies of the first Crusade, and even stranger tales of what had become of the survivors in those colonies in the years between the Crusades.

Although details about the events leading up the end of the Second Crusade are now sketchy, again because of the effects of the *Repurgo*, it is known that rival Crusader Kingdoms came to war in the Theatre. By 516, war in the Archipelago was raging, and opportunistic ferals and Kells also joined the chaos. In the winter of 517, fleets of people fleeing from the madness that had become the Theatre came into St. Barnabas like so many scolded dogs. In 518, the Scion managed to assemble a host of some 15,000 men to pacify the region anew, but this fleet was never heard from again, and so it is that the Second Crusade comes to an end in that year.

In the years between 518 and 548, the Empire experienced a dramatic increase in atrocious crimes in her cities and towns that were uncommon before this time. Ritual killings and massacres became a common occurrence, and many people went missing from areas that were previously considered safe, such as the civilized cities of the Monastic South and in St. Avitus itself. Though some historians draw a connection to the demographic crisis of those years, with so many able-bodied men having vanished over the seas in the first half of the 4th century, it is doubtless that the Black Faith was beginning to take hold in Avilund, its poison starting to course through the veins of Empire.

By 548, crimes of this sort, and crime and chaos in general were endemic in the Empire. There were too few nobles and senior clergy remaining after the failed Second Crusade to deal with all the problems at home, and for the first time in its history, the Empire found itself dealing with the problem of incarceration. There were too many criminals to house and manage reasonably, and while there were many proposals for dealing out harsher punishments for lesser crimes (hanging for just about everything), this solution was just not palatable for the people of this time. The Scion of the time, **Malregard Avitus Vanderwail** (389-568), was enterprising and resourceful like his father, Lothar. Like his father before him, he was visited in his sleep by his great ancestor, St. Avitus, who claimed that a safer rout to the Holy Archipelago could be found by going overland through the West, rather than heading East in boats in what had become a perilous time for navigation. Malregard claimed that in the dream, St. Avitus had a golden stag at his side, and behind the stag were many Saints. The Scion promptly ordered the creation of the **Ordo Croceus Cervus** (Order of the Golden Stag), and declared the pilgrimage through the Western Theatre in his famous, publicly delivered oratory and declaration of the **Occasus Bellum Via**, on August 29, 548.

At this point in History something new happens in the Ecclesiastic Empire of Men. The Pilgrims of Vander, which at this point in history are headquartered in the town of St. Barnabus, announce that they

would not follow the orders of the Scion, largely because of the refusal of the Prelate of Ulric to comply with the conditions of the pilgrimage. It is not difficult to imagine that the High Marshal of the order and the Prelate of St. Ulric would have been nonplussed at the appointment of a new order to carry out what had been their business for the last two hundred years. But there was an even larger problem; Malregard declared in his oration that the time had come to create the **Magnus Collego Sanctus**, a great collection of the Sainly Artifacts from all of the Canons, to be kept in the Valdenwail, in order to secure them against the uncertainty of the time, and to safeguard them while the fighting orders were away from home. The Ordo Croceus Cervus would be charged with protecting this reliquary for all times. This did not sit well with the Prelates of many canons, St. Ulric none-the-least. The Prelate refused to surrender Salm, Ulrics battleaxe, as well as the other artifacts of the Canon, and other Prelates followed his lead. This was the first recorded schism of the PDF, the first act of non-compliance by any Prelate.

It is suspected that the Scion created some sort of secret order or agency that was charged with the procurement, by any means possible, of all the Sainly Artifacts in Avilund. Several smaller Canons that refused to submit to the terms of the Scion did have their artifacts go missing. However, there was never any known documentation of proof that the Scion had a hand in this, and to be sure, there was a growing preponderance of the Black Faith in those times that might have had the same larcenous goal.

The Ordo Croceus Cervus was gearing up for their march along the Occasus Bellum Via, and many of the less-seditious canons backed this Crusade and the Order that was leading it. This is the Crusade of Saint Severinius, whose Canon was chosen to back the Ordo, and see to the spiritual well-being of the pilgrims. The body of St. Sever was relocated to the Magnus Collego Sanctus in a great ceremony in November of 548, and interred in the Collego, and the Mace of the Ordo Croceus Cervus was bestowed upon the Prelate of St. Sever by the Scion himself on that day in the Valdenwail.

Religious and political tensions in the Empire were at a zenith in 549; the problems of crime and criminals had not lessened, and more than half of the Sainly Canons followed the lead of the Canon of St. Ulric, and refused to surrender their artifacts to the Scion and his reliquary. The Prelate of St. Sever, no doubt acting under the direct orders of the Scion, declared that any Canon that did not submit its artifacts to the reliquary could not partake in the Pilgrimage along the Occasus Bellum Via. This caused great pressures for the noncompliant Canons; it was suspected that this organized march into the West would be the first great opportunity to safely secure lands west of the Sea of Sorrow and the Devils Plain, and they sorely wanted to be involved. To make matters worse, artifacts continued to be stolen from the smaller Canons, and some Canons actually lost their Holy Writ from the Scion because of this. To this day, it is still Canonical Law that a Faith can only maintain its Writ so long as it can provide physical evidence of the Sanctus Mortuis. Some of the Saint in question. Despite the fact that there are no known surviving artifacts some of the larger faiths, such as that of Judith and Sebal, the PDF was still able to wield this rule selectively, and apply pressure on some Canons that were poised to loose Writ. The Canon of **St. Theobald**, for example, was given the chance to maintain Writ after the body of their Saint was stolen, by declaring that they would submit all their holdings in the Western Theatre to the Vanderwails. This was a common agreement that kept several Canons alive.

This all seems like a more protracted explanation for background events for the Third Crusade, but it is important to understand the religious and political tensions of the time, to understand what happened next. Late in June of 549, the Scion and the Ordo Croceus Cervus were getting anxious to get the pilgrimage under way, but they were having a difficult time assembling what they thought was a suitable expeditionary force without the inclusion of the Canon of St. Ulric and the backing of the Pilgrims of Vander. Those Historians that give Malregard a generous degree of credit claim that he foresaw the difficulties and the slight schism of the PDF, and knew that those who would remain loyal to him would be of insufficient numbers to mount a proper pilgrimage. As the season grew late and the small army of the Ordo became a greater burden upon the City of Lysander, the staging point for the pilgrimage, the pressure to assemble the needed men and get things underway became severe. At this point, Malregard penned the **Propositum Servitus**, which declared that any criminal who served under the banner of the Golden Stag for one year in the Western Theatre would be a free man at the end of that service, and be entitled to lands in the Theatre. And so in one stroke of the pen, two great problems were solved; the jails were emptied all over the Empire, and a suitable host was assembled in Lysander by the end of September. It is worth noting that

this mobilization happened much faster than logistically possible for the time, and it is doubtless that this measure was planned out in great detail long before the Propositum was put to paper and made legal.

While the problem of bolstering the crusading expedition had been solved, there still remained the religio-political problem of the Collego, and the sedition of the Canons to deal with. The Scion was worried, and rightly so, that once the armies of his loyal subjects were thousands of miles away in the Western Theatre, that the influence of those that stayed home, Ulric and Ignatius in particular, would become too potent. Malregard devised a plan that might have worked, if not for a protracted bout of terrible luck much later on, and the unforeseen deviousness of some Prelates. He knew that the Prelate of St. Ulric desperately wanted to join the Pilgrimage, as it would certainly be a lucrative venture, and that crusading is at its core the essence of the Canon of St. Ulric. Malregard offered an amendment to his demands upon the PDF to submit their artifacts to the Collego; he declared that any Canon that would bring its artifacts to bear in the Western Theatre could retain them afterwards, and that any Canon loosing Sanctus Mortuis Somes as a result of the pilgrimage would not loose Writ. This declaration brought the Canon of St. Ulric and many others (though not St. Ignatius) into the Pilgrimage, and also assembled the greatest number of religious artifacts ever gathered together.

Finally, on 3 December, 549, the host marched from Lysander and into the Western Theatre, with more than 100,000 men, half of which were criminals under the banner of the Golden Stag. This was a slow and deliberate Crusade. The veteran campaigners of the Pilgrims of Vander insisted on a forced march through the desert and into whatever lands were to be found beyond, but the Ordo took a different approach. They built fortress after fortress on the long march of decades into the Western Theatre, and was this decision to do so that won them the prosperity that they still enjoy to this day. In the Western Theater, the Men of the Empire found Men of a different variety; the dusky skinned Foreigners, or Westerners, that we know of today. They found many new races and tribes of ferals as well, and between these two new opponents, a forced march could not be maintained. Logistics in the face of a pair of relentless foes would have been impossible, if not for the deliberate fortifying approach of the Ordo. This approach also secured the new road for decades during this Crusade and the later, Fourth Crusade, and many villages and small kingdoms grew out from the walls of the Crusader Castles that line the Bellum Via.

For the next 45 years, the Pilgrimage in the Western Theatre continued, and every summer news would come back from the front of new fortresses built, new kingdoms of westerners defeated, new races of ferals destroyed, new treasures raided and riches flowing back east. And so, every autumn, new recruits headed west along the Bellum Via into the Western Theatre. The Ordo Croceus Cervus became more rich and powerful than the Pilgrims of Vander, and the authority and influence of the Canon of St. Sever reached its height at the end of this Crusade.

By 590, however, things started to change. After more than 40 years of marching westward, there was some doubt about the existence of a passage to the Eastern Theatre, and so the confidence of the pilgrimage was shaken. As well, by this time the pilgrims had met with a very strong kingdom of Westerners which they could make any progress past, let alone conquer. The name of this kingdom is now lost to History, but certainly it must have been spoken in curses for centuries to follow, as it was this kingdom which put an end to the Third Crusade, and in fact mobilized its own crusade, of a stamp, against the Men of the Empire.

In 591, news came back to Lysander that several castles on the front had been destroyed, with entire garrisons massacred. The Crusade had ceased its dauntless progress westward, and fewer people flocked to its cause that Autumn. In 592, heretical news arrived that the front had moved eastward by more than 500 miles, and that many castles were surrendering to the Westerners, and, worse yet, converting to their faith. While there was a brief redoubling of Imperial efforts to fortify the front and cease the loosing of ground to the heathen Westerners, by 593 the front had moved back more than 1000 miles total. The loss of ground and castles in this year was concomitant with the loss of several Holy Artifacts and relics. Several of the artifacts of the Canon of St. Ulric were lost in monumental battles, and those of other Canons vanished in a variety of ways. While there were many rumours about Scions secret order operating in the Western Theatre stealing artifacts for the Collego, doubtless many were lost honestly in the ceaseless advance of the Westerners and their conquest over the Crusader Castles.

In 594 a host of some 7,000 men of both Crusading Orders were assembled in Lysander. They marched off in August, but by October, the van of the heathen crusading army approached the walls of St. Severinius Castle on the Bellum Via bearing grisly evidence of the annihilation of the OCC and PV army that had marched westward 2 months earlier. A siege of the castle ensued, but only briefly. By the time December came, the Western army lifted siege and departed, but the will of the Empire to make pilgrimage in the Western Theatre had been destroyed, and it would be over 800 years before an organized effort to make pilgrimage westward again was made.

This age is associated with the unmasking of the Black Faith as well as the Crusades. In the monastery of St. Irenaeus in 528, a plot to murder the Saintly folk there was uncovered. A warden of the monastery named **Ultan** was found to be practicing some very unorthodox rituals, and he was subsequently arrested, tried and sentenced to death. He was sentenced to hang, but made a full confession and renounced his obscene faith, and requested that he be drowned in the well rather than hang, stating that he did not want his death to become a spectacle that might draw others into the cult into which he had been inculcated. He was thrown in the well with weights around his ankles and drowned. On the Feast of All Hallow's Eve, several months later, all of the residents of the monastery were poisoned by the water from the well, and before midnight the entire population of over 1000 was dead. The bodies were not discovered until the next spring when merchants arrived to trade, and they reported that the bodies had been laid out in a corn field in a specific fashion to spell the name of 'Ultan'. This was the first recorded encounter with this name, and it is not known if the man known as Ultan was possessed by the Devil of the same name, or if he simply affected that name, or if the soul of the man ascended to become the Devil that many theologians are now familiar with.

In 639 the village of Tarmin in the Bishopric of St. Sebald, nearby to Lysander, learned the terrible name of **Sodor**. By this time, the Third Crusade was well over, and the demographic recovery of the Empire had begun. Though the wealth associated with the Crusades had ceased to flow down the Bellum Via, the Empire was making an economic recovery after the blow dealt to it in 594. After 40 years, there was again optimism. However, this was jilted when in the autumn of 639 when traders came to the village and found it completely annihilated. There wasn't a living soul in the village, and the corpses of some 1000 villagers had been mutilated beyond recognition. In fact, the faces of all the villagers had been removed and used to make a gigantic and grisly mosaic which depicted a four-armed devil of some sort. On the doors of every dwelling the name "Sodor" was found scrawled in blood. It is likely that after this occurrence, or possibly even the massacre at St. Irenaeus, that the Scion instituted the Inquisition, but it was not unmasked quite yet.

111 years after the massacre at Tarmin, the Black Faith struck it's most terrible blow to date. In the Autumn of 750, the PDF was sitting conclave in Waldheim. At a large banquet in the Cathedral of St. Avitus, the plotting of the Black Faith was revealed in a well-timed and well-planned out attack upon the Cathedral. Members of the Black Faith had infiltrated many of the Canons that were invited to the banquet, including St. Sever, St. Sebald and St. Ignatius. It was the multitudinous servants of evil in the ranks of the Ignatians that has helped to keep that faith in poor standing in the PDF to this very day. When the high-ranking officials of all the guest-canon were seated, knives were drawn, and terrible magics wielded, and the banquet-hall turned into an abattoir. At the same time, terrible monstrous demons assailed the guard on the streets, keeping them from helping their doomed masters inside. The Scion, **Nicetus Avitus Vanderwail** (700-804) was himself attacked in that bloody banquet, but was able to make his escape with a few of his closest advisors through the virtue of his own great will, or so the stories go. At the end of the night, hundreds of clergy from many canons lay dead and mutilated, the Prelates of St. Ignatius and St. Sebald included. This event remains the most heinous assassination ever successfully carried out in the PDF. When order was restored, the culprits had vanished, but had hung a great banner over the banners of the Scion and the Empire which declared the Avilund belonged to '**Maccul**' and his 'Black Saints'. Thus all three names of the devils had made their debut, their suspected leader last, and his 'Black Saints' announced. This had the intended effect; panic spread throughout the Empire like a fire in a dry plain.

There are more than a few heretical accounts of those days that suggest that Emperor Nicetus had much to gain through the deaths of the Prelates of St. Ignatius and St. Sebald, as well as many other political figures who perished at the banquet. It is theorized that the Scion had proposed the institution of the Inquisition at

the previous Conclave, but the motion was turned down largely through the influence of the Ignatians. Further, it was uncommon in those days for any Canon but those of the First Order to be invited to the Banquet of the Scion, and St. Ignatius alone of the Second Order was invited. Unfortunately, any records that might shed light on this possible conspiracy, heresy though it may be, have never been mentioned. Three nights after the massacre, Nicetus began the terrible age of Inquisition when he made his infamous decree, the **Prospectus Imperialis ex Daemonica**.

Middle Late History

On November 23, 750, as the blood was still being washed from the Cathedral in Waldheim, Nicetus delivered his terrible and heavy handed decree from the Emperors Balcony in the Blue Palace. The face of Nicetus as it withdrew from that balcony after his oration was the last face of any Scion to be seen in public again. They have lived in seclusion ever since the massacre at the cathedral, and none have delivered a public oration since that time. The **Prospectus Imperialis ex Daemonica** was designed to counter the Black Faith, which was seemingly growing in influence and power. That the servants of Maccul could infiltrate the higher ranks of some of the more powerful Canons was worrisome, and thus harsh measures were called for. Inquisitors began to stalk the lands and the cities, and their power was absolute. The birth of the **Prospectus** marks the beginning of the long estrangement of the Canons of the Collegium from the main Saintly Faith. It was their Canons that suffered the most from the Inquisition, for it targeted men of learning and magic specifically.

With the Inquisition set loose upon the Empire, the faiths of the Collegium were greatly reduced in power. Their clergy men were afraid to practice their learned professions, and society as a whole suffered. Records from this period were few even before the *Repurgo*, and are all but extinct today. Despite the efforts of the Inquisition, the Black Faith grew, and their crimes became more ubiquitous and heinous. With every crime or perceived crime of the Black Faith, another Inquisitor was given his letter of marque, and set loose upon the Empire. So it was that the Empire came to have two enemies gnawing at its insides, and so it was that it began to shrink. The Imperial Army was conscripted by the Inquisitors to do their bidding, and were thus unable to do their duties at the borders effectively. The infrastructure was seriously damaged by the in Inquisition as well, as too many farmers and other providers were put to the torch, the water or the noose to generate the surpluses needed to feed the Empire.

The Scion was ever suspicious of the faiths of the Collegium, and as the Inquisition grew in power, many people turned to those faiths for sanctuary. This actually caused a brief period of expansion for these three faiths, and new abbeys were founded in regions that were previously closed to them. The Inquisition was quick to show up in these areas and make life difficult for the clergy and the lay people of these villages. The only limitation the inquisition had to deal with in those days was the Law of Sanctuary, which prevented them from entering any holy place without permission by the senior clergy there. However, in 889, Scion **Tancred Avitus Vanderwail** (804-1009) penned the **Prospectus ex Veneficium**, which not only put an end to that sole limitation of the Inquisition, but it also made the study and practice of any magic other than the Divine, a crime punishable by death. As one could well imagine, this was not well received by the Canon of St. Anselm, and the other Canons of the Collegium backed their ally. All their defiance of the **Prospectus** earned them were visitations by irate and vengeful Inquisitors. With the implementation of the new **Prospectus**, learned men mark the beginning of the **Saeculum Noctis Obscuris**, in which the spread of learning, magic and medicine was completely halted, and practitioners of these professions were forced into hiding. Indeed, many faithful clergy of the faiths of the Collegium were put to death by the ubiquitous Inquisitors, and the divide between these formerly powerful Canons and the Scion and his allies was made broader and deeper.

There is little good that can be said about this age. Imperial citizens were burned, hanged and drown by the hundreds, and the though the death toll can never be accurately figured (outside the walls of the Valdenwail or Dimmantle), it is likely that over one million citizens lost their lives. There would certainly have been many practitioners of the Black Faith amongst them, but certainly not one in one-hundred.

By 1019, the Empire was in jeopardy of collapsing completely. There were no longer enough people left to feed the big cities, and famine and disease became rampant in these places. The city of Avitus (Waldheim) endured a long plague that killed 2 people in 5, and in Lysander, there was enough famine to cause riots in what is normally the most well-governed and disciplined people of the Empire.

In the North, things happened that caused all of this to change. The Kingdom of Heirgallad had suffered the Inquisition so badly that it had not a single farmer left to feed what was left of the Kingdom. The entire Kingdom was but a single winter from starvation and extinction. At this time, a great host of Kells marched upon Castle Heirgallad, and when King Armund of Heirgallad rode out to meet the King of the Kells to find his terms, it is said that the Kell stroked the emaciated flank of the horse, shook his rivals weak hand, and wept. He turned his army about immediately, and left his dying enemy alone for the rest of that century.

News of this encounter reached Mantlethorn. Though the two northern Kingdoms had been on-again off-again allies and enemies, King Aeginthorn showed his quality by declaring a lasting piece with his neighbour, and provided what little assistance his people could to see them through the winter. Aeginthorn and Armund gathered what nobles and men-at-arms they had remaining, and they rode to Avitus, where they delivered a Declaration of Succession at the Blue Palace. They were quickly arrested in the Palace, many of their nobles and men killed almost immediately by the overzealous Inquisitors who watched over the proceedings there. However, the Steward of the Blue Palace ordered the Inquisitors to stand down and to unhand the two kings and their men. They were kept as 'guests' in the palace for several months, while word of this was brought to the Scion in the Valdenwail. The Scion of the Time, **Maiolus the Forgiving, Maiolus Avitus Vanderwail** (1009-1210), heard the story of the Kings, and it is rumoured that he too wept at the story of the Kells, and how the men of the north would rather come to their certain death in the Blue Palace, than live under the Crimson Banner of the Empire. He immediately ordered all Inquisitors out of the Northern Provinces, and sent aid there to make amends. This was the first stroke against the First Inquisition.

The second and fatal stroke would fall in Hamstonfast in the Bishopric of St. Ignatius in October of 1021. The infamous Inquisitor Kerrigan came to this village and put all 900 of its citizens to death during his investigation there, including his own retinue. When word of this reached Maiolus, he immediately put an end to Inquisitorial Authority, and had many Inquisitors themselves tried in the Valdenwail, where their fates became unknown and lost to those lonely halls. Though the Inquisition was formally ended in December of 1021, it was several years before all of the Inquisitors in the field were rounded up and called home, and their barbarous atrocities endured, though in a much-reduced fashion.

What followed was not a rebirth of Learning, Magic and Medicine. The citizens of the Empire were forever scarred by the Inquisition, and still feared to do anything they would have done during the bloody years of the Prosepecti. Unfortunately, the Empire still stayed curled up inside itself, afraid to once again stand and stretch, so effective were the Inquisitors of the Scion in their dreadful duty.

Almost 200 years past between the end of the Inquisition and the *Repurgo Imperialis*. Little happened in those between years; the Empire was stagnant, and there were some small internecine conflicts over scarce resources, though nothing on a scale worth mentioning in this short historic survey. All students of History are strongly encouraged to read, copy and study Dr. Carrington's *Cruentus Novae res Sanguinius Satus Compleo* which gives a much more detailed and in-depth account of the closing days of the *Repurgo* and the Second Inquisition, and the most detailed accounting of the *Novae res Sanguinius* ever compiled. Below, these events will be given a cursory illustration.

In 1210, the Casparian Monk **David of Sandalstone** arrives on the set of History. He had taken the Rule of St. Caspaar into a perverted context which suggested that all learning and records were heresy and an affront to St. Avitus and the Saintly Faith. His misinterpretation of the Rule could not have been planted in more fertile soil. Though the rivers of blood and mountains of corpses left behind by the First Inquisition had vanished over the previous 200 years, their memory was fresh, and the terror they left behind just as sharp and clear as it was when Kerrigan walked in Avilund. Adding to this was the fact that society had not been much improved by the end of the Inquisition, which was largely blamed on the Black Faith, and

those who supported it. The list of Black Faith supporters was of varying length, depending on what region one takes into account, and the level of education of the interpreter. However, it was not difficult to convince the simple folk of those unenlightened days that the Clerk or the Money Lender to which they were heavily indebted had much to do with the Black Faith. David had a natural talent for identifying enmity in a new village, and was quick to orate to the poor masses and turn them against the objects of their enmity. By 1212, the Casparians were in every province of the Empire, setting entire libraries and schools to the torch, and stringing up those learned men which they perceived to be members of the Black Faith. Just about every one who could read was a target of the Casparians, and in this time, having followed a long and bloody period of purgation of the educated elite, the illiterate were legion, an angry and armed legion. The *Repurgo* seemed especially focused on destroying such things as maps and instruments and records of navigation. So it was that the Canon of St. Caspaar and St. Ignatius came to an irreconcilable conflict which persists to this day. This conflict is the first open non-secular internecine conflict of the Saintly Faith, and it was this conflict that drew the attention of the Scion.

The fires of St. Caspaar outlived David by a century, but the drive and hatred he held was found in countless Caspaarians in the decades following his death in 1248. By 1295, the Prelate of St. Caspaar, **Eugene of St. Caspaar**, declared an open war on the Canon of St. Ignatius. This declaration was illegal as per the Rule of St. Sever, and so the Scion, **Baudri Avitus Vanderwail** (1210-1350) became involved. He publicly denounced the declaration of war, stating that Eugene did not have the Saintly Authority to order it, but he took no further actions himself. Rather, he reinstituted the Inquisition, and again, the lights in the unsleeping towers of Dimmantle light up, and riders issued forth. It is certain that the Emperor was suspicious of the actions and motivations of the Caspaarians, and it is also certain that elements of the Black Faith had been heavily involved with this Canon from the start of the *Repurgo* in 1210. It is often rumoured that David himself was likely possessed, but this can in no way now be verified.

It is important to understand that a change in the power structure of the Empire had taken hold in the years since the end of the First Inquisition. The Saintly Faith had lost some currency as a protector of the people, and the societal ideal we know today as the Feudal Kingdom was entrenched. In the Northern provinces especially, people began to pledge themselves to a landed and powerful warlord, who, for a share of the crops they harvested from his lands, he swore to protect. These warlords became knights, barons and princes, and all swore allegiance officially to the Emperor, but in practice served their liege, or local king. In the large towns and cities, opportunistic men who saw profit in the regulation of the limited resources of the times became known as burghers. The nobility and the merchants gained a level of power they had not held previous to the First Inquisition, and they were about to take one step back and two forward.

There is no doubt that Baudri was the most blood thirsty Scion to ever rule in the Valdenwail. It was rumoured that he personally stalked the lands as the “**Inquisitor Beodreath**”, and tales of this man still scare children and adults alike to this day. Whether this historic figure, inflated as he likely is, was actually Baudri or not is a matter for academic debate in ale houses, and not the class room. What is uncontested is that Baudri backed the bloodier of the two Inquisitions, the Second. His Inquisitors were even more ruthless than those of Nicetus and Tancred. How such policies and practices could come from the Son of Mailous is another matter for less structured academic debate, but is puzzling all the same. Beodreath was known to erect forests of corpses on pikes, and though the First Inquisition was ended when a single village was obliterated, Inquisitors of the Second left dozens of such scars on the Empire.

One must not forget that the Caspaarians were doing the same to the empire at the same time, though to a lesser degree. There were many Caspaarians put to the pike by Inquisitors of this age, but there are many records surviving that terrible time of Inquisitors conscripting the already-seasoned butcherous mobs of the Caspaarians into their retinues. It was a terrifying time for anyone in Avilund in that age; the people were struggling not only with the triple internal threat of Caspaarians, Inquisitors and Black Faith (though the smarter Black Faithful no doubt kept a low profile in this age), but the Kells again returned to harass the Northern Provinces, and a number of Feral warlords had grown powerful enough to march into the Bishoprics of St. Sebal (Lysander) and St. Ignatius. Therefore, the True Faithful of the Learned Saint, and the much-needed Crusading Orders had more trouble than they could handle, and could not provide a military check to the slaughter of the time.

Though body counts are always a dodgy matter in any conflict, this one is even more difficult to put a number to. There were just too few records left, and too few people willing to account for what they had seen, lest they become the next corpse on a pike. However, many scholars have since devoted their entire academic careers to assessing the damage of this ungovernable era, and there is a general agreement in the Community that it was doubtless not less than 3 million killed, possibly double that. The number would represent about 1 citizen in 8, or possibly 1 in 4, finding their death at the hands of the Caspaarians and the Inquisitors. A terrible number, to be sure.

The end of the Second Inquisition was not to come from the North this time. The Northerners had more than enough trouble than they could handle with the Kells, and indeed offered but token nobles to the Revolution that was about to happen. It was in the City of St. Avitus (Waldheim) in 1346 that change took hold. A council of nobles calling themselves the **Order of Bellweather** formed, in response to the fires and corpses choking the streets of their Province and City. Through much plotting and the complete elimination of Saintly leadership in their Order, they managed to put together a small army of some 3000 men, who, on Oct 1, 1346, rounded up the senior clergy of every major and minor Canon in the City, and had them gently imprisoned in the Blue Palace. The Order appeared on the Emperors Balcony, 5 hooded men who clearly wore the gowns and trappings of nobility, and declared the City independent of the Rule of the PDF and the Scion. They declared that the Clergy would no longer have any political authority in the City, and that until the bloodshed of the Inquisition ceased, all senior clergy would remain imprisoned. They also changed the name of the City to Waldheim, which it remains today.

The elicited the response one would expect from the Scion; Baudri was a hot head and a blood thirsty maniac, and sent word to every Inquisitor stalking the Empire that they were to attack the City at once, and put the Order of Bellweather to the pike or the fire as soon as possible. The Inquisitors of the Second Inquisition were man terrible and able things; they were able to turn sons against mothers, and invoke fear in the hearts of all who saw them, but they were no military force. From November that year, until the Spring of 1347, the Inquisitors arrived piecemeal to confront the Order, and all were met with an organized and growing Republican Army, which was able to repel them, and capture and imprison many Inquisitors.

Baudri eventually called off his Inquisitors, and called a general retreat and regrouping; his Inquisitors and their retinues returned to the Valdenwail and to Dimmantle, where they awaited word from their Scion. The Order and the Republican Army played a very strategic card at that point; the army had grown to over 10,000 men, many of which were now seasoned and confident. They sent two regiments to assist the Bishopric of St. Ignatius in their struggle against the **MacGawnowich Ferrals** in June of 1347, and by the end of August, the Bishopric was liberated from their struggle. This move helped to ingratiate the newly-founded Order and the Republican Army with the staunch supporters of the PDF, and resulted in more support and more troops.

In the south, the **Dungorgon Ferral Horde** which had been pressing back the Crusading Order armies of Lysander retreated, no doubt suspecting that the human armies would unite to bring the ferrals between them for a crushing victory. If their generals knew of the animosity between the Crusading Orders, which still mostly supported the Scion, and the Republican Army, they would likely have stayed, and the world would be a different place. However, they did not.

Unfortunately, the strict dogma by which the Crusading Orders lived their lives was more than enough to make them blind to the madness of Baudri, and as the Dungorgons retreated, they regrouped and planned to march upon St. Ignatius and Waldheim. Emisaries from both the Order and the Ignatians were sent to make peace with Lysander and her Knights, but this could not be achieved, and so a long year of internecine fighting took hold. It must have been a pitiful thing, to see the Republican Army and the Crusading Orders fighting over villages which had become nothing more than empty graveyards after the passing of the Inquisitors and Caspaarians who had brought about this struggle. All was not mindless conflict though; the Pilgrims of Vander refused to take the field against any army which bore the standards of any Saintly Canon, and it was not long before every Republican Army found itself aided by a spiritual advisor, usually an Ignatian. However, the Ordo Croceus Cervis followed the orders of the Scion without a thought, and many unfortunate battles across the Imperial South and the in the Imperial Septum could not be avoided.

The Crusaders were able to muster strength as they marched across the South, towards the Valdenwail, just as the Republic was able to do so as it marched through the Nith Valley, until it crossed the Antiquitus Via. At this point, the Republican forces were split into four; the Northern Army, which marched to assist the Northern Provinces with their struggles against the Kells, the Ignatian Relief Army, which had helped in the war against the MacGawnowiches, and now fought against the OCC in the Bishopric of St. Ignatius, the Waldheim Army, which held the City against any threat, and the Expeditionary Army, which marched over the Septum and into the Imperial South with the aim of setting siege to the Valdenwail.

It is the actions of the Expeditionary Army which historians of the **Novae Res Sanguinius** are chiefly concerned with. On August 17, 1347, this division of 7000 men and 1000 heavy horse crossed the Septum with little resistance, but found a large garrison in St. Mairin's Gate at the base of the mountains. The pass down to the Gate gave the Republican Army the benefit of high ground, but they had no siege engines, nor did they wish to use such indiscriminate weapons for their cause. Further, though it was lower down in the mountains, the Gate was and is situated on a great bluff which commands the plain beneath it, and it has only a small and vulnerable mountain road leading to it which would cost the Republic dearly to use. **General Woefall Ulmar**, the leader of the Expeditionary Army decided to make a forced march past the Gate, enduring the artillery which the Crusaders no doubt had entrenched in the Gate. It cost them dearly to pass; over 2000 men and 400 horse were killed in the mad rush down the pass and onto the plain. The artillery continued to harass the Expeditionary Army until it was out of range. At that point, **General-Brother Moldan Grist** rode out with his Crusader-Brothers and the men-at-arms they had conscripted along the way. They numbered some 4000, 700 of which were Crusaders, and fighters of the finest sort.

On the olive plains below St. Mairin's Gate, the two armies positioned themselves, across a small valley. A tent was erected, and the Generals and their staffs met to discuss terms and Rules of Combat. However, Ulmar had a dirty trick up his sleeve. During the negotiations, alarms sounded up in the Gate as a portion of the Waldheim Army which had marched in secret a day behind the main Expeditionary Army charged down the slopes and overran the Gate. This small detachment of about 1500 men now commanded the Gate and its artillery, which the main force of Grist's army was now at the mercy of. The discussion between the two Generals in the tent is a thing of well-recorded legend. There are poetic and lengthy accounts of it in several documents, but the summary of it was this; that Ulmar smiled as he saw the furrowed brow of his opponent harden at the realization of what was happening up in the Gate. Grist had guessed what had happened without having to get word from outside the tent, and though he grew angry, he smiled. Ulmar is known to have said the following;

"I am loathe to turn your instruments of war against you or any other Goode Man of Avilund. I have sacrificed many pawns to get you onto this Honourable Field, and now you see the Queen ahead of you, prostrate and vulnerable, for I know that my new Army could not master the discipline that the Pilgrims of Vander possess. You may strike at the queen, but you will leave the King vulnerable; you will be destroyed by your own artillery. Please good and Honourable Knight, please acquiesce!"

Grist is known to have said the following.

"You misguess your role, General. We are all but pawns." And he departed the tent. Ulmar is known to have blanched.

The Battle of Olive Plain commenced less than an hour after the tent was struck. It is sometimes called the Battle of Tears, for both sides could see the faces of their adversaries across the valley, and knew them for countrymen and kin, and many wept that they should cross blades. However, the discipline of General Grist was absolute, and though the trebuchet and cannon were poised on the bluff above to cripple his army with a single wave of a black flag in the ranks of his opponents on the other side of the valley, he knew his duty, and he charged. The report from the cannons above was terrible; it was the first time Men of Avilund fired the new and terrible weapons at each other, and it was terrifying for both sides. The conscripted men-at-arms of the Crusader force broke quickly under the terror of those guns, but the Pilgrims of Vander themselves charged out, and though they were but a tithe the strength of the Expeditionary Army, they

killed and routed over half of it, and General Ulmar himself was cut down in the battle. In the end, the Pilgrims all lay dead, having fought to a man upon a heap of their Brothers.

After this battle, the Expeditionary Army halted at the Gate, and held the pass all the rest of that year, awaiting reinforcements. With the Pilgrims of Vander all but destroyed, and the Ordo Croceus Cervus locked in siege with the Ignatian army in that Bishopric, the Imperial South lay open to the Republican Army. However, it did not advance until the following spring when a portion of the Northern army returned from their wars in the north with the Kells. They were reduced in number to about 3500, but that was enough to bring the spirits of the wintered Expeditionary Army to a fighting level. This force now numbered over 8000, many of them veterans. However, word soon reached them from the Ignatians that the OCC had lifted siege, and was making its way as quickly as possible to the defense of the Valdenwail. The OCC would have to cross the Septum and travel over 600 miles to make the Valdenwail. The Expeditionary Army was but 350 miles from the Valdenwail, and thus things looked good for the Republic.

However, the Expeditionary Army would not get to the Valdenwail before some troops arrived to reinforce it. Though different historical accounts must be examined to piece together what happened next, it is now a thing of legend-cum-fact that 300 of the most senior Brothers of the Golden Stag departed in great haste from the main of the OCC force. They were never seen by their brethren again. In July, when the van of the EA approached the Hedge, they were met with 300 heavy horse who all wore ancient armour from the early days of the *Saeculum Maximus Congregius*. With them was a small retinue of emissaries from the Valdenwail. The van never made the approach across the valley before the Hedge. They lost their nerve, each and every man, and turned back.

A week later, when the main force approached the valley before the Hedge, they found the same 300 mounted men in their ancient armour and the retinue awaiting talks. There was one masked member of the Order of Bellweather leading the Army, and he had several experienced Captains and two Generals with him, but none of them could find the courage to cross the valley under the terrible glare of those 300 sentinels. The Scion's retinue rode out ahead of their ominous guard, and awaited a council from the newly founded Republic, but after a few hours, when it did not cross the valley, there was heard a great cackling in the valley, and the retinue and 2/3 of the sentinels departed, heading back into the Hedge.

At this point there was much desertion. The Captains ordered a siege be set, but more than half of their men left that very night, and in the morning, not a single siege machine had been erected. Parties were sent to round up deserters, and messages sent to Waldheim requesting more help and advice. The awkward cycles of desertion and round-up, attrition and re-supply continued for two more months, until the cool Autumn fell upon the haphazard siege. Unfortunately, at this point the main force of the OCC arrived on the right flank of the siege, and another great battle was to be fought. Brother-General Maxamillian Grudge, the leader of the OCC wasted not a moment in deliberations. As he arrived on the field on September 28, 1348, his men positioned for battle immediately. The EA tried to make the preparations required to meet them, but the will of that camp was still unsettled, and they made a terrible resistance for so large a force. Though they numbered about 10,000 at that point, the OCC was only 2500, counting some 240 Crusaders among them. This battle, The Battle of Hedgefield, was a terrible and chaotic affair that the Crusaders were well suited to. Every one of the Crusaders and the men-at-arms of the OCC fought to the death, at when the dust settled, there were only 1900 men of the EA left standing, with no Captains or Generals among them. The only leader left alive was the masked Bellweather, and he was ready to call a retreat. News had come that the Crusading Orders in Lysander were mounting a second wave, and though it would be markedly more anemic than the two forces the EA had already faced, they knew that the men could not bear to meet with such enthusiastic opponents again. Add to this their unwillingness to march a single step towards the ominous hedge and its handful of awe-inspiring guardians, and it seemed that the 'siege' of the Valdenwail had come to an end. They made preparations to strike the camp. The next day brought better news, though; the Ignatian Army, which had been on the heels of the OCC, was nearing, and a great host was coming down from the City to reinforce. This was barely enough to keep the tattered remains of the EA in place, but it did.

By October, the two forces did arrive nearly simultaneously from the West and the North. The EA was surprised to see the Ignatian Army in such good shape; they had to cross 600 miles of the Imperial South,

which had never loosened its allegiance to the Scion in any province, and it was still a populous region. However, the Ignatian host arrived unscathed with a full complement of 8000 troops, and the Waldheim Regiment with another 4000. As they arrived, the full complement of 300 sentinels again rode out to face them from across the valley, and again, it had the intended effect on most of the men. However, the Ignatians did not falter. While thousands of men around them lost their nerve and broke, the Ignatian Host remained as an island of resolute will. It was at this time that they unveiled the great Palanquin which bore the body of St. Ignatius inside a gilded glass box, suspended some 60' in the air. The banners of the Ignatians were all waved in rally and defiance, and the grim sentinels on the opposite side of the valley shuffled a bit. The unveiling of the shriveled and grisly Artifact rallied the rest of the Armies, and they stood as a single unified host of almost 14,000 across from the Hedge. Though they had been rallied, they would not charge against those 300 sentinels, though. So it was that siege was again set, and this time, the engines from St. Mairins gate were brought to the line to threaten the Hedge.

On October 30, 1348, the emissaries of the Scion again rode out from the Hedge, and this time, they rode to the nape of the valley under flags of truce to meet with the generals of the Republican Army. This time, emissaries from the RA did in fact ride down to meet them. They had many generals, 3 masked Bellweathers, and many bishops among them, including **Prelate Scaerwyn of St. Ignatius**. There are very few accounts of what transpired at this meeting; those from the Republic that were there never revealed nor recorded any of the proceedings. It is known that a tent was struck up, and after several hours, most of the Republic retinue was dismissed, except for one Bellweather and the Prelate of St. Ignatius. Several hours later, they again returned to the tent bearing a great chest, which some thought would be a bribe of some unfathomably valuable treasure. The tent was struck down shortly after that, and both retinues rode up the hill towards the Hedge, and past the parting Sentinels. Presumably, they met with the Scion himself somewhere inside the Hedge in some secret and forgotten building, and a day later they emerged. Prelate Scaerwyn addressed the Army on the morning of October 31 as the sun was rising. His speech is well documented in a number of accounts, and sounded much like this;

*Good and Saintly Men of Avilund, I present to you (as he held aloft a great parchment) the **Placitum a Terminus Potentia**, signed by Emperor Baudri himself last night at the stroke of midnight. This document releases the people of Avilund from the Rule of the Emperor. The Empire is no longer! The Tyranny of the Inquisition and the evil of Men in Avilund has come to an end. Peace has replaced murder, prosperity has replaced famine. All Men are now Free to choose their Leaders and their Laws as they see fit. I know that we will all choose Goode and Saintly men to lead us, and we will be free of the Absolutism of an Emperor. The Scion is now Emperor of the small Ecclesiarchy on the other side of that Hedge alone. And though he and his descendants will always hold their sacred position as Scion and Spiritual Figurehead of our Saintly Faith, he and his will no longer rule our lives from within his obscure walls. Peace and Independence have come to Avilund! Return to your homes and govern yourselves in Goode and Saintly fashion! But never forget that Peace was won at a terrible price.*

The Placitum itself and the long-term effects of the word-of-the-law printed upon it are matters for more in-depth studies of the Novae Res Sanguinius. However, Scaerwyn did in fact bear that document to the people on that morning, and the Empire did come to an end that very morning, and the Modern World was born. But, it was won at a terrible price, as the Prelate had mentioned. It was not long before it was discovered that the remains of the body of St. Ignatius had been removed from its glass tomb on the Palanquin, and that the terrible price that Scaerwyn was talking about was not only the cost of blood and the lasting pangs of the battles of Men against Men, but also the Holy Artifact of his Canon. The body of St Ignatius found its way, no doubt, to the Magnus Collego Sanctus that very day.

Modern History

At the end of the Bloody Revolution, the Empire did indeed come to an end as it was, though the power of the Emperor was not limited to control over the IEV as Prelate Scaerwyn would have wished. All of the Provinces of the Imperial south maintained a non-secular government which ruled pretty much as it had before the Revolution. They simply adopted the title of Bishoprics rather than provinces, with Prelates at the head of the government, instead of the Scion (though orthodox Prelates such as those of Sebal and

Mairin still acquiesce to the Scion). These Ecclesiarchies dominate the South. In the Wen and Nith Valleys, the old Imperial provinces became republics and democracies based on the governmental model of the newly formed Republic of Waldheim. The exception is the unique Bishopric of St. Ignatius, which is an ecclesiastic government, but which does not acknowledge the preeminence of the Scion as a secular leader. In the northern provinces, the feudal kingdom again flourished, and the old lines between the kingdoms of Mantlethorne and Heirgallad were again drawn.

This process of choosing governments was not a fast or smooth transition from Imperial Rule. There was turmoil in almost every old Imperial province except for Waldheim, where the Order of Bellweather saw to the peaceful and expeditious creation of the Senate, which promptly elected the three Consuls who form the head of that state. This system of government in Waldheim continues to this day. Senates and Consuls under many different names were put in place in most of the new states of the Wen and Nith Valleys. It is important to note that the Order of Bellweather handed over power completely and permanently to the Senate and the Consuls, and though it still exists today, it is more of a fashionable and mysterious gentleman's club, rather than a political entity.

Though the *Placitum a Terminus Potentia* stripped the rights of the Scion to intervene in matters of law and government outside of the IEV, placing the right to make government and laws as the people saw fit, it specifically revoked the *Prospectus Imperialis ex Daemonica* and the *Prospectus ex Veneficium*, nullifying those laws in all the Lands of Men, in Avilund and the Theatres. This was an important detail of the Placitum; the Ignatians likely knew that in the Imperial south, Non-secular governments and old Imperial hard liners would still back the Scion and rule by His laws. They did not want the Inquisition to walk in any of those lands under any government, and ensured that the faiths of the Collegium would be allowed to flourish in all parts of Avilund, the south included.

This foresight of Prelate Scaerwyn allowed for the flourishing of not only the faiths of the Collegium, but the age known as the **Saeculum Ingenium Aurum**, which many scholars believe still persists to this day. This Golden age of Invention is typified by a proliferation of education and medicine. Good medicine in the Cities allowed for healthier populations free of plagues and other urban maladies, and the populations again began to rise, though to date they have not risen to the high-water mark of the Pre-First Inquisition Empire. Study of the Culture and Society of the Elders again continued, and Universities were reopened in many cities, Lord's in Waldheim included (Lord's had actually reopened its doors in 1347 after the Bellweathers took power).

This age is probably best symbolized by the invention of the Printing press. The first printing press was actually built in the Bishopric of Lysander, in the Abbey of the Artillery, the same abbey of St. Dunstan which is accredited with the creation of gun powder in the late 1200's. They graciously shared their invention with the faiths of the Collegium, and to date there have been more than a dozen of these wonderful apparati constructed, including Lord's Press at Lord's University, upon which this very text was stamped.

The spread of education, learning and medicine was fast and had immediate and tangible positive implications for Avilund. However, the spread of Magic did not make the same recovery from the darkness of the *Repurgo* years and the Inquisitions as did the other disciplines of the Collegium. To this very day, superstition about magic abounds, and just about any magic that is not of Divine Origin (miracles performed by the Saintly) is labeled as 'Black Faith' or 'Black Magic'. The fear of the Inquisitors is still felt to this day. The study of magic, by most reliable accounts, has proliferated to some degree, but its practice is not a matter for public consumption, and public use of magic will more often than land the practitioner of the Art in a great amount of trouble.

In fairness to the Masses (ignorant though they be), there remains a large element of the Black Faith in Avilund today. With the end of the authority of the Inquisition, the surviving members of this faith no doubt saw an opportunity to again spread and grow. It is a matter of public fact that the City of Waldheim is home to several sects of the Black Faith, though they are mostly clerigied by rogues and well-to-do dilettantes. Some Ignatians, especially those of the Order of the Candle, report an increase in the number of

cases of demonic possession and ghostly hauntings since 1348, but this is likely an acceptable and preferable consequence to the ending of the Inquisition.

As the Men of Avilund again took control of their continent, and were prospering and growing, they again began to look to the Holy Theatres. By the late 15th Century, there was a tremendous interest in the Western Theatre especially, as a new and unprecedented level of wealth in the Cities demanded exotic goods and further trade surpluses. Fortunately, Baudri had died long ago, and his son, **Eustace Avitus Vanderwail** (1350-1510) was a more humanitarian and charismatic Scion, reminiscent of his grandfather, Maiolus. Eustace was known as the **Crusading Scion** for his initiating the 4th Crusade.

The political landscape for this Crusade was quite different from those that lead to the earlier Crusades. Where previously genuine Religious interest and the need for more lands for the Second Estate were motivating factors, trade was the catalyst for the 4th. Of course, Eustace implemented the Crusade in the name of Pilgrimage, and he likely had a genuine interest in the Holy Land, but he undoubtedly was pressured by the Prelates of his neighbours in the south to help them to boost their trade to catch up with the other nations north of the Imperial Septum. The Western Theatre has always been a brass ring of sorts, for it is known to be rich in gold and other valuable trade commodities such as spices and fabrics, and so it was a logical conclusion that the old Imperial south would again benefit from opening the Bellum Via.

The 4th Crusade would be known as St. Dunstan's Crusade. In 1486, Eustace gave charter to the **Ordo Divinius Regimen**, the Order of Divine Guidance. This name is not a reference to the guidance of the Saints, but rather to the artillery innovations that the clergy of St. Dunstan were making. Their cannons were already legendary apparati capable of firing huge bombs hundreds of yards at an enemy, and no walls could withstand them.

Between 1486 and the Autumn of 1488, the city of Lysander again saw its streets choked with men from all over Avilund, as news of the Crusade spread throughout the continent. The Scion took a more organized approach to launching this Crusade than had been previously employed; The ODR traveled through Avilund spreading word that the Crusade would leave on a chosen and specific date; October 31, 1488. This gave the Men of Avilund two years to mobilize, and resulted in a more concentrated and organized beginning to this Crusade. By late Summer of 1488, Lysander was charged with the excitement of 150,000 men from all of the Crusading Orders, and many other groups and organizations besides. Many wealthy merchant companies chartered huge mercenary outfits to go on the Crusade and open new trade routes. From the Northern Kingdoms, both Kings gathered hosts of over 10,000 men each, and pledged them to the service of the Prelate of St. Dunstan, who was the spiritual leader of the 4th Crusade. The Order of Bellweather provided 5000 men which served under one masked Lord, who himself pledged his services to the Marshal of the Pilgrims of Vander.

With all the different groups and their myriad goals and motivations, one would expect that this Crusade would have been doomed from its inception. However, this Crusade was to be different than the last two, which did fail because of the Politics of Men. This time, the Scion himself came to Lysander, and he declared himself High Marshall of the Crusade. He marched at the Van, with the Marshals of the three Crusading Orders and the Kings of the North with him. Such a retinue of powerful men had not been collected together since the defense of the Valdenwail in 450 BC. Though the Marshals of the OCC and the PoV, and the Kings of the North might have had inbred and lasting contention with the Scion as a matter of political tradition, none were able to defy the man in person, and all pledged themselves to him, kissed his ring and conducted themselves most honourably thereafter.

On October 31, 1488, the Host of the 4th Crusade did indeed march out from Lysander and down the Bellum Via. For the next 22 years, the Armies of the Men of Avilund marched ever westward, reclaiming all the old castles of the 3rd Crusade as they did so. This time, they found that the men of the West were more united than before. After the defeat of the Saintly in the West at the end of the 3rd Crusade, the men of the West were unified under the banner of a single leader, and thus the Western Empire, called the **Grevusgloom Empire**, was born. When the Men of Avilund returned, they found their opponent in a somewhat relaxed state. The first several castles and settlements along the Bellum Via were easily taken, especially with such an enormous Host and the deadly artillery of the Dunstanites. In fact, many

capitulated without a single blow falling in anger. Before the New Year, riches were already flowing back over the mountains and into Avilund, and by the Spring of 1489, a second wave of Pilgrims, Crusaders, settlers and merchants were headed into the Western Theatre. In that year, another 40,000 men went into the west, most of which were combatants. However, with the riches that were flowing back by the wagon load, there were many settlers and families of nobles and military leaders coming to make a new and profitable life in the West. Year after year, Avilund sent tens of thousands of people into the West, and new and larger villages and towns sprung up around the Castles of the Bellum Via. Many villages were of mixed races; the people of the Grevusgloom Empire were allowed to keep possession of most of their homes outside of the important castles and strong holds, for the sake of peaceful trading once the war moved past their doorsteps. There are a number of excellent texts about this Crusade, and some very excellent Sociological examinations of the lives of the people of the mixed villages that merit reading and studying. The arrangement was so favourable that it wasn't long before the Westerners were coming back with some of the caravans and settling in Lysander and some of the other towns of that Bishopric.

The lives of the Westerners in Avilund were certainly not easy in those early days of the 1490's. They were clearly identifiable by their darker skin, black hair, dark eyes, strange dress, language and customs. But they adapted to the Culture of Avilund quickly, many flocking to the Canon of St. Sever immediately. Ironically, it is in the City of Lysander, known for its strict religious intolerance that these people thrived the best. In smaller places, they were often accused of being demons and worshipers of the Black Faith and were subject to the same kinds of atrocities that the Inquisition had inflicted just 200 years earlier.

In the years between 1488 and 1510 the Crusaders fought westward, and left a wake of trade and new settlements behind them. They managed to get as far as the heart of the Grevusgloom Empire; the City of Grevustople, in the year 1507. This city, at the end of the 2200 mile long Bellum Via was reported to have walls hundreds of yards thick in its vital places, and was garrisoned by an army of 200,000. Though this is likely gross exaggeration, the fact is that the defenses were adequate enough to withstand the artillery of the Crusaders, which the Crusading Scion had the bad sense to deploy before he sued for a diplomatic solution. Siege of Grevustople was laid in December of 1507, and it lasted for 2 years. The entire time, the Crusaders were harried by an Order of Western Knights who bore banners with a black lion, and have thus been called the Order of the Black Lion ever since. This order, like our own Crusading Orders, is a religious fighting unit, and it proved to be a worthy adversary.

Soon after the siege was laid, and the Black Lion began to harass the Crusaders, the Scion called for reinforcements to be brought up from the rear settlements. By this time, there must certainly have been a half million settlers and soldiers in the West, but they were too concerned with holding and fortifying their lucrative positions in the towns they had taken and settled. Even though such a staggering number of Men of Avilund were in the Theatre at the time, the Scion could muster only 120,000 for the siege of Grevustople, which was insufficient. Finally, in November of 1509, the Scion lifted the siege and made a withdrawal from Grevustople. It is likely that he was being strongly urged by powerful elements in the rear, as they began to enjoy a comfortable and profitable life and didn't see the need to carry on further west. However, the Scion did not relent, and would not rest. He marched his army around the great city, and continued west, intent on finding the passage to the ocean, which by this time was widely rumoured to exist. The Crusading Army by this time had lost the support of the merchant companies and their valuable mercenaries. The Pilgrims of Vander had also sworn too much of their host to the defense of key settlements along the Bellum Via, and both Northern Kings had settled lands just off of the road and could not provide more than a token host.

It is certain that the Marshals of the OCC and the ODR must have counseled against the passing of the great city without taking it and securing their supply line back to their settlements. The venerable Crusading Manuals of the OCC instruct against moving beyond the secure supply line of the rear echelons, in both strategic and tactical terms, and to march around Grevustople and leave it between the Scion and his Crusaders and their support to the east was the doom of the 4th Crusade. Had the timing been different, things might have worked out better. However, a terrible drought in an already-dry climate left the store houses of the villages and towns west of the City nearly empty. The Crusaders were able to conquer town after town with relative ease, but they never found enough food or supplies. Towards the end of the winter, the Crusaders were suffering from hunger and disease, and the Order of the Black Lion could sense that its

quarry was weak. On March 11, 1510, the largest military engagement in the history of both Men of Avilund and of Grevusgloom commenced in the doomed city of Charne, which lay 200 miles west of Grevustople. This was another large city of perhaps 40,000, which was easily taken and fortified by the Crusaders, who had some 100,000 men and many engines remaining. Reports had come that the Black Lion had mustered a host of unheard-of size, and was marching to put an end to the Scion and his Crusaders. Indeed, the Black Lion appeared outside the stone city with between 300,000-400,000 men, and they encircled the city and began a ruthless siege. Charne was a city of two great circular walls, one within the other, making two lines of defense. The Crusaders withdrew to the inner wall almost immediately, and the horde of the Black Lion took up in the city around the inner wall soon after. The engines of the St. Dunstan began to dismantle the outer ring of the city immediately, and the losses to the Lion were tremendous. However, their weight of numbers brought them over and through the inner wall, where they fought in close battle on the streets and in the houses and halls of that doomed city. As one hall or large building was taken by the Lion, the Crusaders would direct their artillery at it, destroying it and those inside. This back-ward and inward creeping obliteration continued all day, until at dusk the last of the Scions host was forced into the castle-hub of the centre of the city, being entirely encircled by their opponents. By this time there were only about 600 Crusaders left beside the Scion, everyone a seasoned and hardened veteran of decades of warfare. They were encircled by about 100,000 Black Lion. There was a brief pause in the fighting, as the Lion was ordered to halt their advance. The Crusaders were lodged in a tough spot, and to root them out would have cost the Lion dearly. However, their general ordered the captured siege engines to be brought up and brought to bear against the walls of the castle in which the Scion and his men were trapped. It had grown dark by this time, but the Lion had great fires light all around the machines in order to display them to their caged-quarry, and the Scion agreed to meet with the general of the Lion to discuss terms.

The terms of the Lion were this; The Scion would engage in singular combat against the Lions Champion, a giant named Golgoza. If he won the combat, he and his men could leave peacefully and march wherever they wish in the lands of the Grevusgloom Empire, in search of their passage and their Holy Land. If he lost, his men would be accompanied back eastwards along the Bellum Via, and order every castle and settlement emptied and returned to the Grevusgloom Empire. The negotiations took several hours, and it was agreed that at midnight the battle should commence. The Lion had several artists in their retinue, and the battle between Golgoza and Eustace has been immortalized in several paintings, sculptures, songs and poems. Golgoza was a terrible opponent, being over 10' tall and muscular like a beast. He used a great heavy cauldron swung on a chain as his weapon. The Scion was a man of usual stature, but his Divine Blood was true, and he was a man of extraordinary strength, speed and stamina. He fought with the heirloom weapon of his family, the ancient axe known as Beighteghar, which before the 4th Crusade, had not been swung in anger since the 5th century BC.

The divine quality of the Scion should have been enough to win this battle, fearsome though Golgoza was. The Scion had bested a number of creatures of the same race as Golgoza over the last couple of decades in the Theatre. However, what was not known to anyone but the Scion himself, was that that Scion had already been fatally wounded during the fighting earlier in the day. He had been stabbed through the back with a terrible Lion blade, which had broken off inside him. This was not revealed until the end of the singular combat. The battle commenced, and the Scion was quick to cut the hamstrings of his large opponent. He took his time racing into to take singular swings at his now-crippled opponent, then quickly charging out of range again. Golgoza managed to strike Eustace twice with his huge cooking-pot-cum-morning-star, and in both instances, the Scion was sent hurtling into the audience, where the men that broke his terrible flight were slain.

After the second such flight of the Scion into the crowd, he was slow to recover, and he staggered forward to face his opponent for a final attack. As he raced towards his opponent, onlookers could see that things would end soon; the Scion left a trail of blood from his now-exacerbated sword wound on his back that might